

Stamp Collection Inventory & Valuation

User Guide

A practical workflow for turning stamp photos into a reliable, sortable inventory and a cautious value estimate.

Version 2.0

What version 2.0 improves

- A clean template now starts at zero - no demonstration row is counted as part of your collection.
- Blank control rows stay blank instead of showing distracting zeros.
- The TOTAL row always covers the full Inventory, even if you do not build a country breakdown.
- The AI helper now returns the exact spreadsheet columns in paste-ready order.
- Instructions use one consistent workflow across Excel, Google Sheets and LibreOffice.

Your five tabs

Tab	Use it for
About	Collection details, valuation basis and the live headline totals.
Inventory	One row per stamp or one row per group of identical duplicates.
Per photo	Independent completeness check for every image.
Progress	Track which album pages are photographed and inventoried.
Summary	Full totals plus an optional per-country breakdown.

Before you begin

Choose what the estimate is for: personal record, realistic sale, insurance replacement, or another clearly written purpose.

Use one valuation basis consistently. Catalogue value, asking price and sold price are not interchangeable.

Keep an untouched backup of the template before entering data.

1. Set up the workbook

- Open Stamp-Inventory-Template.xlsx. Use the SAMPLE workbook only to see a completed example.
- On About, complete the yellow cells: owner, purpose, valuation basis, catalogue, currency, date and notes.
- The template uses EUR formatting by default. In Excel or Sheets, change the monetary cell format if you work in another currency.
- Do not overwrite line_value or total cells; these are calculated.

2. Photograph carefully

- Photograph one album or stockbook page at a time.
- Use even light, avoid reflections, keep the camera parallel and fill the frame.
- Use clear filenames such as blue-album-p012.jpg. Use the same filename in Inventory, Per photo and Progress.
- For potentially valuable stamps, also photograph the front and back at high resolution.

Safe handling

- Use stamp tongs. Do not clean, soak, peel or flatten stamps.
- Keep stamps dry, cool and away from direct sunlight.
- Leave stamps on covers or pieces unless a qualified expert advises otherwise.

3. Enter the Inventory

- Use one row per stamp. Group only genuinely identical duplicates and enter their quantity.
- Always enter quantity 1 for a single stamp. line_value equals est_unit_value multiplied by quantity.
- Use country_as_printed for the inscription and country_normalized for the modern or standard country name.
- Use low confidence when a reading is uncertain. Never turn an AI guess into a firm identification.

4. Understand the colour flags

Colour	Meaning	What to do
Gold	research_priority = high	Check a catalogue and recent comparable sold results.
Blue	needs_physical_check = yes	Inspect back, watermark, perforation, gum and faults.
Coral	id_confidence = low	Verify country, issue and denomination before valuing.
Yellow	est_unit_value input	Enter the estimated value for one stamp only.

5. Prove that nothing was missed

- On Per photo, enter the exact filename and your independent count of stamps visible in that image.
- Distinct entries captured counts Inventory rows. Stamps captured includes duplicate quantities.
- OK means the visible count and captured quantity agree. CHECK shows the difference.
- Resolve every CHECK before treating the inventory as complete.

6. Track progress

- Use Progress for every album section and page, even if a page contains no valuable stamps.
- Set Photographed? and Inventoried? to yes only when each step is complete.

7. Read Summary

- TOTAL always reflects the complete Inventory.
- For a country breakdown, type country_normalized names in Summary column A exactly as used in Inventory.
- About displays the same live headline totals.

8. Value cautiously

- Identify the exact issue and catalogue reference before comparing prices.
- Choose one basis: catalogue, realistic sold price, or insurance replacement. Record it on About.
- Prefer completed or sold marketplace results over unsold asking prices when estimating a likely sale price.
- Compare like with like: mint versus used, hinged versus never hinged, perforation, watermark, gum and faults.
- Enter a per-stamp estimate in est_unit_value. The workbook calculates line_value and totals.

High-risk identifications

- Overprints, classic issues, errors, scarce shades and many colonial stamps are frequently misidentified or forged.
- A catalogue match is not authentication. Obtain expert advice or a certificate before relying on a high value.
- Do not use the workbook as a tax, insurance or legal appraisal without professional confirmation.

Using the AI Photo-ID Helper

- Upload one clear photo at a time and paste the supplied prompt.
- Ask for tab-separated output using the exact Inventory headers.
- Paste values into Inventory starting at column A. Do not paste into line_value; leave that field blank so the workbook calculates it.
- Check every low-confidence row against the stamp itself.

Backup routine

- Keep one master workbook, one dated backup and the original photos.
- After a long session, save a new dated copy before major sorting or bulk edits.
- When moving between Excel and Google Sheets, re-check dropdowns, colours, currency and totals.

Troubleshooting

Problem	Check
Total stamps is too low	Enter quantity for every Inventory row, including 1 for a single stamp.
Per photo shows CHECK	Confirm filename spelling, visible count and duplicate quantities.
Country breakdown is blank	Type the exact country_normalized value in Summary column A.
line_value is blank	Enter both quantity and est_unit_value. Do not type in line_value.
Colours or protection changed in Sheets	See Google-Sheets-Notes.txt and re-check after import.

Final check before you rely on the result

Every photo reconciles; every page is logged; every Inventory row has a quantity; all low-confidence and high-priority stamps were reviewed; the valuation basis and date are recorded; valuable items were independently verified.